

A+E
A look at the best places to catch holiday lights across Chicagoland



STILL THE GREATEST

Forty years later, former Tribune reporter Don Pierson looks back on the Bears' Super Bowl season. **Chicagoland, Page 4**

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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

SPECIAL REPORT

'OUT OF MONEY IN NO TIME'

When hospitals choose private guardians, patients often end up paying the price

By Emily Hoerner, Christy Gutowski and Lisa Schencker
Photography by Eileen T. Meslar | Chicago Tribune

During a wellness check in February 2023, a Cook County sheriff's deputy discovered 92-year-old Anna Vargas lying face down on the floor near the body of her son, who had diabetes and died of natural causes.

Vargas, still breathing, was rushed to nearby Advocate Lutheran General Hospital in suburban Park Ridge. A physician diagnosed Vargas with severe cognitive impairment due to dementia and concluded she was incapable of making her own decisions.

With no other family to help the nonagenarian navigate what would come next, the hospital filed a petition asking a judge to appoint a guardian to handle her affairs.

It was the start of a very expensive 18 months for Vargas.

The law firm the hospital hired to handle her case and the private care management organization the hospital

Turn to Guardianship, Page 2



Anna Vargas paid Midwest Care Management and Monahan Law Group nearly \$49,000 in total hourly fees and costs before being transferred to the care of the Cook County public guardian.

ONE CENTURY, ONE ROAD

A mostly obscure Kansas native who later set up shop in Rogers Park, Bruce Goff cast futuristic designs that are enjoying a renaissance up and down the Route 66 corridor



The rebel architect

By Jonathan Bullington | Chicago Tribune

People who saw the strangely shaped house being built in Aurora — its red curved steel ribs, a black coal wall dotted with marbles and glass cullet — had different names for it, Life magazine reported in 1951. Some called it a "birdcage." "Big apple." "Dome." "Hangar."

Their comments were enough for its owners, Chicago Academy of Fine Arts director Ruth Van Sickle Ford and her husband, Albert, to put a sign outside that read: "We don't like your house either."

Nearly eight decades after it was built, the Ford House continues to be one of the best examples of the ingenuity that sprang from the mind of architect Bruce Goff — and the mixed reaction that creative wellspring could elicit.

The Kansas native has been called an "outsider" and a "rebel," the best architect the public's never heard of, a master of organic architecture and a prodigious talent whose relentless desire to never copy himself or anyone else is one reason he's often not mentioned in the same breath as Frank Lloyd Wright, Louis Sullivan or Ludwig Mies van der Rohe.

Goff designed more than 500 buildings in a career that started at 12 and ended with his death 66 years later. Most were set in middle America. The Ford House is one of eight he built in Illinois, including two in Chicago, where pre-World War II, he established a private practice in Rogers Park

and taught at Ford's academy.

Goff's eclectic designs — at times angular, curvy, futuristic, Seussian — and innovative use of nontraditional embellishments — glass ashtrays, feathers, sequins, coal — mirror the kinds of quirky attractions that have become synonymous with Route 66. (Architectural historian and writer Charles Jencks once dubbed him "the Michelangelo of kitsch," a description Goff reportedly bristled at.)

And like the famed roadway, which celebrates its centennial next year, Goff is in the midst of a cultural resurgence of sorts.

Turn to Rebel, Page 12



A photograph of architect Bruce Goff, above, hangs inside the Sam and Ruth Van Sickle Ford House, top, which was designed by Goff in Aurora and finished in 1950. E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS

Amid the blitz, US attorney facing ire

Critics fear politics fed into decision to charge protesters

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

In the four months since U.S. Attorney Andrew Boutros was appointed to an open-ended term as Chicago's top federal prosecutor, his office has seen a large turnover in leadership, been buffeted by the government shutdown and thrown headlong into the controversial Operation Midway Blitz immigration enforcement mission.

Unusual times to be sure. But then last week, things got even weirder.

After dismissing several criminal cases against protesters of the Trump administration's aggressive immigration enforcement policies, the U.S. attorney's office was called to the woodshed in an extraordinary opinion by a federal magistrate judge that lit up the water cooler talk in legal circles.

In granting the prosecution's motion to dismiss assault charges against Dana Briggs, U.S. Magistrate Judge Gabriel Fuentes took the opportunity to opine more generally on the U.S. attorney's office's role in prosecuting a number of other immigration-related cases that have since fallen apart.

In his nine-page opinion, Fuentes wrote he could not "help but note just how unusual and possibly unprecedented it is" for Chicago's venerable U.S. attorney's office

Turn to Charges, Page 8

INSIDE

Hefty amount of snow hits region

As snow blanketed the area Saturday, more than 1,000 flights were canceled at the city's airports and road conditions grew hazardous. **Chicagoland, Page 10**

PHYSICALITY IN PHILLY
Offensive line paved the way for Bears' big day. **Chicago Sports**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 34 Low 15

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 20

\$5.75 city and suburbs and elsewhere
178th year No. 334 © Chicago Tribune

